

Rationalism - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Rationalism - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

RAPID REVISION 1 - Rationalism Master Map and Basic Tenets

Rapid recall

- Reason supplies necessity and universality; sensation may still occasion thought.
- Core tenets: innate resources, a priori certainty, deduction, intelligibility and substance.
- Descartes begins with doubt; Spinoza with strict substance; Leibniz with sufficient reason and simple units.
- The trio's substance count is **3 -> 1 -> infinity**.
- **Trap:** do not call rationalism a unanimous doctrine about God, freedom or the number of substances.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 1, 3, 21 and 22 test the school-level operating logic.

RAPID REVISION 2 - Cartesian Doubt, Cogito and Certain Self-Knowledge

Rapid recall

- Doubt is methodical, hyperbolic and temporary.
- Sequence: sense error -> dream -> evil demon.
- "I am, I exist" is secure whenever conceived.
- Cogito is immediate, not syllogistic.
- Initial certainty concerns thinking existence, not yet an enduring soul.
- **Trap:** epistemic priority of self is not automatically metaphysical proof of dualism.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 1, 17 and 25; PYQ 2022 Q4(b).

RAPID REVISION 3 - Wax, External World, Divine Guarantee and the Cartesian Circle

Rapid recall

- Wax qualities change; judged identity remains.
- *Inspectio mentis* grasps extension, flexibility and mutability.
- Hats and coats: apparent seeing includes judgement.
- World-proof comes later through involuntary ideas and divine non-deception.
- Cartesian Circle: clear/distinct perception proves God; God guarantees clear/distinct perception.
- **Trap:** "Cogito, ergo sum" is not the wording used in the *Meditations*; preserve the provenance distinction.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 2, 3, 9, 22, 25 and 30.

RAPID REVISION 4 - Substance: One Inherited Criterion, Descartes 3, Spinoza 1, Leibniz Infinity

Rapid recall

- Shared criterion: in itself and conceived through itself.
- Descartes: God absolutely; mind and matter as dependent created substances.
- Spinoza: one infinite substance; Thought and Extension are attributes.
- Leibniz: infinitely many simple, active, windowless monads.
- Bodies in Leibniz are well-founded phenomena, not ultimate substances.
- **Trap:** never call Spinoza's Thought and Extension two substances.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 4, 7, 8, 18, 19 and 28; PYQ 2018 Q2(a).

RAPID REVISION 5 - God: Cartesian Guarantee, Spinozist Immanent Nature, Leibnizian Selector

Rapid recall

- Descartes: trademark, ontological and conservation routes; God is no deceiver.
 - Spinoza: *Deus sive Natura, causa sui*, immanent cause, no discretionary creation.
 - Leibniz: PSR, necessary being, best possible world, harmony.
 - *Natura naturans / naturata*: active nature / order of modes.
 - **Trap**: pantheism is not the claim that God is only the visible aggregate of finite things.
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 9-11, 18, 19 and 29; PYQs 2020 Q4(b), 2024 Q2(b).
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RAPID REVISION 6 - Mind and Body: Interactionism, Parallelism and Pre-Established Harmony

Rapid recall

- Descartes: real distinction plus interaction; pineal gland is not a conceptual solution.
 - Spinoza: same order, two attributes; no cross-attribute causation.
 - Leibniz: windowless monads and synchronized clocks.
 - Ryle's "ghost in the machine" is Ryle's hostile later label, not Descartes' phrase.
 - **Trap**: harmony is not occasional divine intervention after creation.
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 8, 12-14, 24 and 31; PYQ 2024 Q3(c).
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RAPID REVISION 7 - Freedom and Determinism Across the Rationalist Trio

Rapid recall

- Descartes: will wider than intellect; error when assent outruns clarity.
 - Spinoza: no contingency; bondage is inadequate external determination.
 - Leibniz: spontaneity, intelligence, contingency; reasons incline without necessitating.
 - Absolute freedom belongs only to Spinoza's God.
 - **Trap**: Spinoza's freedom is not an exception to causation.
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 15-17, 20, 24, 26 and 27; PYQs 2018/2020/2023/2024.
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RAPID REVISION 8 - Spinoza's Integrated System: Necessity, Knowledge, Pantheism and Negation

Rapid recall

- I Def. 7: freedom through one's own nature.
 - I P15: whatever is, is in God.
 - I P16: infinitely many things follow from divine necessity.
 - I P18: immanent, not transitive, cause.
 - I P29: no contingency in Nature.
 - II P7: order and connection of ideas and things is the same.
 - Knowledge: imagination -> reason/common notions -> *scientia intuitiva*.
 - **Trap**: cite structural references, not fabricated page numbers.
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 4-6, 10, 13, 15, 18, 19, 23, 26, 29, 31 and 32.
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RAPID REVISION 9 - Leibniz: Monads, Sufficient Reason, Contingency and Harmony

Rapid recall

- Monad: simple, unextended centre of perception and appetite.
- "No windows" is the standard rendering of *Monadology* section 7.
- PSR asks why this fact/world rather than another.
- Complete concepts settle the actual series.
- Infinite analysis distinguishes contingent from necessary truth.
- Freedom: spontaneity + intelligence + contingency.
- **Trap:** synchronized correspondence is not causal interaction.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 7, 8, 11, 14, 16, 20, 24 and 27; PYQs 2018 and 2020.

RAPID REVISION 10 - Criticisms, Comparisons, PYQ Routing and Provenance-Safe Answer Architecture

Rapid recall - comparison and answer grid

Trigger	First route
certain knowledge	doubt -> cogito -> wax -> God -> world
substance	common criterion -> 3/1/infinity
God	guarantee -> immanence -> selection
mind-body	interaction -> parallelism -> harmony
freedom	alternatives -> adequacy -> intelligent spontaneity
Spinoza quotation	structural citation plus provenance check
Leibniz necessity	certainty is not logical necessity

- **Trap:** do not attribute Ryle's phrase to Descartes.
- **Trap:** do not place *Cogito, ergo sum* verbatim in the *Meditations*.
- **Trap:** do not universalise Spinoza's Letter 50 phrase without mentioning Hegel's rendering.
- **Practice link:** the 14 solved PYQs, 32 MCQs and three solved original Mains questions follow immediately.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 40 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-24 preserve the core themes; Questions 25-40 provide remediation across recurring confusions. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D ten times.

MCQ 1

Descartes' doubt is primarily:

A. methodical and temporary B. permanent scepticism C. theological faith D. sensory relativism

Correct answer: A - methodical and temporary

Explanation: It clears unstable beliefs to find an indubitable foundation. The alternatives confuse a temporary foundational procedure with a settled sceptical doctrine.

MCQ 2

The wax argument chiefly shows:

A. wax is unreal B. bodily identity is judged by intellect C. senses never function D. God is extension

Correct answer: B - bodily identity is judged by intellect

Explanation: Changing sensible qualities do not exhaust the judged object. The argument isolates intellectual judgement of identity; the later world-proof is a different step.

MCQ 3

The Cartesian Circle concerns:

A. mind-body interaction B. proof of the world C. mutual dependence of God and clear-distinct perception D. monadic harmony

Correct answer: C - mutual dependence of God and clear-distinct perception

Explanation: Each appears used to validate the other. Arnauld's objection targets the justificatory order, not the mind-body relation.

MCQ 4

For Spinoza, Thought and Extension are:

A. modes B. substances C. illusions D. attributes

Correct answer: D - attributes

Explanation: They express one substance under two accessible aspects. Calling them substances would reproduce the Cartesian scheme Spinoza rejects.

MCQ 5

Spinoza's first kind of knowledge is:

A. imagination/opinion B. reason C. intuition D. recollection

Correct answer: A - imagination/opinion

Explanation: It arises from vague experience and signs and may be inadequate. Its dependence on vague experience and signs explains why it can contain falsity.

MCQ 6

The fourth proportional grasped demonstratively exemplifies:

A. imagination B. reason C. intuition D. revelation

Correct answer: B - reason

Explanation: Discursive mathematical proof belongs to the second kind. The intuitive third kind would grasp the ratio in one act rather than through a demonstrative chain.

MCQ 7

Leibniz rejects extension as ultimate because it is:

A. unreal to sense B. divine C. divisible and composite D. self-caused

Correct answer: C - divisible and composite

Explanation: Ultimate substance must be simple. Divisibility shows that extension describes composites, whereas ultimate units must be partless.

MCQ 8

"Monads have no windows" means:

A. they lack perception B. they are spatial C. they are identical D. they receive no causal influx

Correct answer: D - they receive no causal influx

Explanation: Their changes arise internally. Windowlessness does not remove perception; it removes external causal entry.

MCQ 9

Descartes' God mainly functions epistemologically as:

A. guarantor of clear-distinct truth B. one mode C. aggregate of bodies D. strongest monad

Correct answer: A - guarantor of clear-distinct truth

Explanation: Divine non-deception bridges cogito and stable knowledge. Without non-deception, the move from present intuition to stable remembered knowledge remains insecure.

MCQ 10

Spinoza's God is best described as:

A. transcendent artisan B. immanent substance C. finite intellect D. contingent selector

Correct answer: B - immanent substance

Explanation: God or Nature is the one substance. Immanence means finite things are modes within the one reality, not products external to it.

MCQ 11

Leibniz invokes the PSR to argue for:

A. sensory atoms B. parallel attributes C. a sufficient ground of contingent reality D. denial of God

Correct answer: C - a sufficient ground of contingent reality

Explanation: The contingent series requires a sufficient reason. PSR asks for an explanatory ground of the contingent series rather than another contingent member.

MCQ 12

Cartesian interaction is commonly located at the:

A. heart B. optic nerve C. cerebellum D. pineal gland

Correct answer: D - pineal gland

Explanation: The location does not solve the conceptual causal gap. A bodily location cannot by itself explain commerce between unextended thought and extension.

MCQ 13

Spinozist parallelism says:

A. mental and bodily orders express the same mode B. minds push bodies C. bodies are unreal D. God resets events

Correct answer: A - mental and bodily orders express the same mode

Explanation: II P7 links the order of ideas and things. Parallelism is identity under attributes, not two synchronized substances.

MCQ 14

Pre-established harmony is illustrated by:

A. melting wax B. synchronized clocks C. a thrown stone D. a blank slate

Correct answer: B - synchronized clocks

Explanation: Correspondence occurs without interaction. The clocks illustrate correspondence without causal exchange, unlike Cartesian interaction.

MCQ 15

Spinoza calls absolutely free what:

A. is uncaused B. is random C. acts solely from its own nature D. defeats natural law

Correct answer: C - acts solely from its own nature

Explanation: This is *Ethics* I Definition 7. Spinoza's definition replaces randomness with action from the necessity of one's own nature.

MCQ 16

Leibnizian reasons:

A. never affect choice B. logically necessitate every act C. are sensory impacts D. incline without necessitating

Correct answer: D - incline without necessitating

Explanation: This supports compatibilist freedom. Moral inclination preserves rational explanation while denying contradiction-based compulsion.

MCQ 17

Descartes' error theory says error occurs when:

A. will outruns intellect B. body disappears C. ideas interact D. God deceives

Correct answer: A - will outruns intellect

Explanation: The will assents beyond clear understanding. Error is attributable to misuse of freedom because God supplies no positively false clear idea.

MCQ 18

"Whatever is, is in God" is found in:

A. *Monadology* §7 B. *Ethics* I P15 C. *Meditations* II D. Locke's *Essay* I

Correct answer: B - *Ethics* I P15

Explanation: It states modal dependence on the one substance. P15 states the modal dependence that grounds Spinoza's immanent monism.

MCQ 19

The acosmism objection says Spinoza:

A. multiplies substances B. denies reason C. dissolves the finite world into substance D. accepts creation in time

Correct answer: C - dissolves the finite world into substance

Explanation: The finite appears to lose robust reality. The objection is not that Spinoza multiplies worlds but that finite reality becomes too thin.

MCQ 20

The complete-concept doctrine most threatens:

A. extension B. innate ideas C. pantheism D. contingency and freedom

Correct answer: D - contingency and freedom

Explanation: Predicates fixed in the concept seem necessary. If every predicate belongs to the concept, alternative possibilities need the possible-world distinction.

MCQ 21

Rationalism's deepest common commitment is:

A. reason can disclose necessary intelligible structure B. all senses are false C. only one substance exists D. all wills are free

Correct answer: A - reason can disclose necessary intelligible structure

Explanation: Substance counts and freedom theories differ. This formulation unites the school without falsely imposing one substance or freedom theory.

MCQ 22

Descartes restores the external world after proving:

A. monads B. a non-deceiving God C. parallelism D. common notions

Correct answer: B - a non-deceiving God

Explanation: Divine veracity validates the natural inclination toward bodies. The order cogito -> God -> world is indispensable to Descartes' reconstruction.

MCQ 23

Spinoza's third kind of knowledge is:

A. vague experience B. hearsay C. *scientia intuitiva* D. imagination

Correct answer: C - *scientia intuitiva*

Explanation: It moves from divine attributes to essences in one adequate grasp. It proceeds from adequate knowledge of divine attributes to essences and is not mere fast calculation.

MCQ 24

The safest 2024 mind-body/freedom winner is:

A. Spinoza always B. Descartes without qualification C. none can be compared D. Leibniz under a compatibilist criterion

Correct answer: D - Leibniz under a compatibilist criterion

Explanation: The criterion must be explicitly defended. Leibniz wins only under a responsibility-preserving compatibilist criterion, not under libertarianism.

Remedial MCQ 25

The cogito is best treated as:

A. immediate performative certainty B. a syllogism from "all thinkers exist" C. sense inference D. proof of the body

Correct answer: A - immediate performative certainty

Explanation: Descartes denies dependence on a suppressed major premise. A syllogistic reading would expose the cogito to doubt about its suppressed universal premise.

Remedial MCQ 26

Spinoza's freedom is:

A. randomness B. adequate self-determination C. exemption from causes D. bodily indifference

Correct answer: B - adequate self-determination

Explanation: It is a mode of necessity understood and internally expressed. Adequacy changes the source and quality of determination, although it restores no contra-causal option.

Remedial MCQ 27

Leibnizian contingency means:

A. God is ignorant B. events lack reasons C. the opposite is logically conceivable in another possible world D. complete concepts are false

Correct answer: C - the opposite is logically conceivable in another possible world

Explanation: Certainty is distinguished from absolute necessity. The distinction is modal: non-contradictory alternatives remain possible even when the actual series is certain.

Remedial MCQ 28

Descartes calls mind and matter substances:

A. in exactly God's absolute sense B. because they create God C. because they are modes of Nature D. in a dependent/created sense

Correct answer: D - in a dependent/created sense

Explanation: This analogical use prompts Spinoza's critique. The analogical use explains why Spinoza accuses Descartes of inconsistency rather than simple numerical error.

Remedial MCQ 29

Spinoza is most accurately called:

A. a qualified pantheist/monist B. a simple atheist C. a Cartesian dualist D. an atomist

Correct answer: A - a qualified pantheist/monist

Explanation: His God is impersonal but indispensable as substance. Spinoza rejects a personal transcendent creator but makes God indispensable as the sole substance.

Remedial MCQ 30

The wax argument does not by itself prove:

A. intellectual judgement B. existence of external wax C. sensory change D. priority of self-awareness

Correct answer: B - existence of external wax

Explanation: External existence is restored later through God. The later argument from involuntary ideas and divine veracity carries the existential burden.

Remedial MCQ 31

Parallelism avoids interaction by saying:

A. God pushes both series B. matter causes mind C. one event is expressed under two attributes D. monads exchange signals

Correct answer: C - one event is expressed under two attributes

Explanation: It dissolves the two-substance premise. One event has mental and bodily expression; no divine reset or monadic signal is required.

Remedial MCQ 32

The phrase “all determination is negation” should be handled as:

A. a direct sentence from *Meditations* B. Leibniz’s PSR C. Locke’s slogan D. Spinoza’s Letter 50 idea universalised by Hegel

Correct answer: D - Spinoza’s Letter 50 idea universalised by Hegel

Explanation: Accurate provenance is an evaluative mark-earner. This wording earns a provenance mark and avoids falsely locating the universal formula in the Ethics.

Remedial MCQ 33

For Descartes, error occurs most directly when:

A. the will assents beyond what the intellect clearly and distinctly perceives B. the intellect becomes infinite C. body determines mind under parallelism D. a monad receives an external impression

Correct answer: A - the will outruns the intellect

Explanation: Cartesian freedom includes the ability to assent or withhold assent. Error is not caused by God; it arises when finite understanding does not adequately guide the wider will.

Remedial MCQ 34

Spinoza’s conatus is best understood as:

A. an uncaused choice outside Nature B. each thing’s striving to persevere in its being C. a causal exchange between Thought and Extension D. God’s selection among possible worlds

Correct answer: B - each thing’s striving to persevere

Explanation: Conatus links Spinoza’s metaphysics to his theory of affects. Rational liberation reorganises this striving through adequate understanding rather than abolishing causation.

Remedial MCQ 35

Which Leibnizian term specifically denotes reflective awareness of perception?

A. appetite B. petites perceptions C. apperception D. extension

Correct answer: C - apperception

Explanation: Every monad perceives, but rational and conscious awareness requires apperception. Appetition is the internal principle of transition from one perception to another.

Remedial MCQ 36

The most careful standard reply to the Cartesian Circle claims that:

A. God is unnecessary at every stage B. the cogito is inferred from a syllogism C. remembered reasoning is more certain than present intuition D. present clear intuition compels assent, while God secures memory and extended reasoning

Correct answer: D - present intuition is distinguished from remembered certainty

Explanation: This reply narrows the circle without conclusively dissolving it, because the proofs of God themselves contain extended chains of reasoning.

Remedial MCQ 37

In Spinoza's ontology, Thought and Extension are:

A. attributes of the one substance B. two created substances C. finite modes outside God D. windowless monads

Correct answer: A - attributes of the one substance

Explanation: Minds and bodies are finite modes expressed under Thought and Extension. Treating the attributes as independent substances would reintroduce the Cartesian framework Spinoza rejects.

Remedial MCQ 38

Leibniz's claim that this is the best possible world primarily means that:

A. every event is pleasant for every individual B. God selects the optimal compossible total order under sufficient reason C. evil is an illusion produced by inadequate ideas D. only one world is logically conceivable

Correct answer: B - optimal compossibility, not maximum local comfort

Explanation: The best-world thesis concerns the total balance of order, variety and compossibility. It therefore still faces the problem of evil rather than defining evil away.

Remedial MCQ 39

Which sequence most accurately states how Spinoza and Leibniz respond to Cartesian dualism?

A. both preserve causal interaction between mind and body B. Spinoza multiplies substances while Leibniz reduces them to one C. Spinoza unifies substance, while Leibniz preserves plurality without interaction D. both deny the existence of body

Correct answer: C - monist unification followed by non-interacting pluralism

Explanation: Spinoza dissolves the interaction problem through one substance and parallel attributes. Leibniz restores many simple substances but coordinates them through pre-established harmony.

Remedial MCQ 40

Which statement best distinguishes spontaneity from autonomy in the Rationalism comparison?

A. spontaneity always means absence of causes B. autonomy always requires random choice C. both mean bodily motion caused by an immaterial mind D. spontaneity is internal origination, while autonomy adds rational self-governance

Correct answer: D - internal origination is not yet full rational self-rule

Explanation: Leibnizian spontaneity concerns action flowing from the monad's own principle; autonomy is the stronger notion of intelligent self-government. Neither by itself proves libertarian freedom.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - Rationalism Master Map and Basic Tenets

Verified routes and marks-wise architecture

- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks:** define the basic tenets and map each tenet onto Descartes' reconstruction.
- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks:** explain why a shared school still produces three classifications of substance.

10 marks: define rationalism -> distinguish it from denial of experience -> give three tenets -> one thinker-specific example -> qualification. **15 marks:** add the mathematical model, innate-idea dispute, intelligibility thesis and one internal tension. **20 marks:** use a thesis that shared method does not force shared ontology; compare how first principles generate the three systems and assess the underdetermination objection.

Demand trap: "basic tenets" requires a school-level account before the answer narrows to Descartes.

EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Cartesian Doubt, Cogito and Certain Self-Knowledge

Verified route and answer architecture

- **2022 Q4(b), 15 marks:** contrast immediate self-knowledge with mediated world-knowledge.
- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks:** show how methodic doubt and cogito embody rationalist tenets.

10 marks: stages of doubt -> performative cogito -> *res cogitans* -> one limitation. **15 marks:** distinguish certainty of existence from knowledge of substance; compare self and world; add the "there is thinking" objection and reply. **20 marks:** reconstruct the complete methodological role of doubt, analyse the criterion of clear and distinct perception, and show why the cogito is secure while the system remains dependent on God.

Directive trap: "critically discuss" requires judging the move from thinking occurrence to substantial self, not merely narrating the Meditations.

EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Wax, External World, Divine Guarantee and the Cartesian Circle

Verified routes and marks-wise architecture

- **2019 Q1(d), 10 marks:** reconstruct the proof of things other than self and God.
- **2022 Q4(b), 15 marks:** use wax and divine veracity to distinguish self from world.
- **2025 Q2(a), 20 marks:** place wax, God and world in the rationalist system.

10 marks: cogito already secured -> involuntary ideas/passive faculty -> non-deceiving God -> material cause -> qualify sensible qualities. **15 marks:** add wax, clear/distinct rule, Circle, current-versus-remembered reply and a reasoned verdict. **20 marks:** audit the whole deductive arc and show that Meditation II supplies intellectual priority while Meditation III supplies the fragile bridge.

Demand trap: never say that the wax argument itself proves an external wax.

EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Substance: One Inherited Criterion, Descartes 3, Spinoza 1, Leibniz Infinity

Verified routes and marks-wise architecture

- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks:** the central comparative substance question.
- **2022 Q2(c), 15 marks:** Spinoza's substance and pantheistic consequence.
- **2025 Q2(b), 15 marks:** determination, finitude and negation within monism.

10 marks: common definition -> 3/1/infinity table -> one sentence on the mechanism of each count -> one cost. **15 marks:** derive one thinker's classification, add objection/reply and compare with the inherited criterion. **20 marks:** explain the reason for divergence, not merely the views; use the dialectical sequence, gains, costs and a conceptual verdict.

Demand trap: a table without the mechanism of divergence does not answer "what is the reason for the difference?"

EXAM APPLICATION 5 - God: Cartesian Guarantee, Spinozist Immanent Nature, Leibnizian Selector

Verified routes and marks-wise architecture

- **2019 Q1(d), 10 marks:** Descartes' God as bridge to the world.
- **2020 Q4(b), 15 marks:** infinitely many things following from divine necessity.
- **2024 Q2(b), 15 marks:** "Whatever is, is in God."

10 marks: identify the role -> reconstruct one proof or proposition -> state consequence -> one objection. **15 marks:** distinguish transcendent, immanent and selecting functions; add personality/necessity criticism and reply. **20 marks:** compare proof, world relation, freedom and explanatory cost across all three, ending with a criterion-based verdict.

Demand trap: "Whatever is, is in God" is ontological dependence, not spatial inclusion and not merely creation.

EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Mind and Body: Interactionism, Parallelism and Pre-Established Harmony

Verified route and marks-wise architecture

- **2024 Q3(c), 15 marks:** rank the rationalist mind-body accounts against human freedom and free will.
- **2018 Q1(b), 10 marks:** harmony and Leibnizian freedom.

10 marks: define the selected mechanism -> one analogy/text -> freedom consequence -> one weakness. **15 marks:** compare all three on ontology, causation and freedom; explicitly defend a winner. **20 marks:** reconstruct the interaction problem, show how each system changes the premise, and assess economy, experience and responsibility separately.

Demand trap: "compatible with freedom" is not answered by neutral description; state the freedom criterion before ranking.

EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Freedom and Determinism Across the Rationalist Trio

Verified routes and marks-wise architecture

- **2018 Q1(b), 10 marks:** freedom under pre-established harmony.
- **2020 Q1(b), 10 marks:** monads, determinism and freedom with own comments.
- **2019 Q2(c), 15 marks; 2023 Q1(c), 10 marks:** Spinozist necessity and freedom.
- **2024 Q3(c), 15 marks:** comparative ranking.

10 marks: define the thinker's freedom -> causal setting -> named example -> qualification. **15 marks:** distinguish alternative possibilities, self-determination and compatibilism; compare objection and reply. **20 marks:** integrate substance, God, mind-body and freedom, showing why each freedom theory follows from its ontology.

Demand trap: Leibnizian certainty must never be equated without argument with logical necessity.

EXAM APPLICATION 8 - Spinoza's Integrated System: Necessity, Knowledge, Pantheism and Negation

Verified routes and marks-wise architecture

- **2019 Q2(c), 15 marks:** necessity-what is cannot be otherwise.
- **2020 Q4(b), 15 marks:** infinite consequences of divine nature.
- **2022 Q2(c), 15 marks:** substance and pantheism.
- **2023 Q1(c), 10 marks:** freedom through one's own nature.
- **2024 Q2(b), 15 marks:** God alone absolutely real.
- **2025 Q2(b), 15 marks:** determination and negation.

10 marks: proposition/definition -> causal consequence -> ethical meaning -> brief criticism. **15 marks:** derive the doctrine through structural references, state objection/reply, and deliver a thesis-first verdict. **20 marks:** integrate substance, attributes, modes, knowledge, parallelism and freedom; distinguish pantheism from acosmism and preserve provenance discipline.

Demand trap: “comment” on determination-negation requires a pointed judgement, not a general essay on all of Spinoza.

EXAM APPLICATION 9 - Leibniz: Monads, Sufficient Reason, Contingency and Harmony

Verified routes and marks-wise architecture

- **2018 Q1(b), 10 marks:** place for freedom under harmony.
- **2020 Q1(b), 10 marks:** how monads bear on determinism and freedom.
- **2018 Q2(a), 20 marks:** why simplicity produces infinitely many substances.

10 marks: monad definition -> windowlessness/harmony -> three freedom conditions -> contingency objection. **15 marks:** add complete concepts, possible worlds, PSR and infinite analysis; assess whether alternatives are genuine. **20 marks:** compare Leibniz's repair of Descartes and Spinoza, showing gains in individuality and costs in divine coordination.

Demand trap: “own comments” requires an explicit evaluative paragraph, not an implied preference.

EXAM APPLICATION 10 - Criticisms, Comparisons, PYQ Routing and Provenance-Safe Answer Architecture

Complete verified corpus route

The continuous local 2018-2025 Paper I bank contains **exactly 14 Rationalism-owned question-parts**: two each in 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025; **2021 has none**.

10 marks: direct definition, 2-3 named anchors, one worked example, one qualification and a compact verdict. **15 marks:** direct thesis, 4-6 anchors, derivation or comparison, strongest objection/reply and a graded ruling. **20 marks:** explain the mechanism behind the system, integrate subtopics, use 5-8 precise anchors, audit presuppositions and conclude at the conceptual level.

Evidence pattern: claim -> named text, proposition or canonical example -> what it proves -> limitation.

Final trap: do not fabricate quotations, translations or page numbers merely to appear textual.

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 14 Rationalism-owned questions; 2021 has none.
- Model solutions: retained from the complete canonical Rationalism session and kept at examiner-grade depth.
- MCQs: 24 core themes plus 16 remedial themes, exactly 40, strict A-B-C-D rotation eight times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Contemporary linkage: no reliable time-sensitive doctrinal anchor was needed or used.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is exact verified PYQs -> 24 core MCQs -> 16 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED TEXT/EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION/REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 14 VERIFIED RATIONALISM QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. The set contains two Rationalism-owned questions in each covered year and none in 2021.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q1(b), 10 marks

Question: Is there any place for freedom in Leibniz's philosophy, when he speaks of 'pre-established harmony'? Discuss.

Model solution

Leibniz's pre-established harmony denies causal interaction among monads, but it does not reduce agency to external compulsion. Each monad unfolds its states from its own internal principle of perception and appetite; *Monadology* §7's "windowless" thesis therefore supports **spontaneity**, the first condition of freedom.

Freedom additionally requires **intelligence** and **contingency**. A rational monad acts for perceived reasons, not by blind physical impact. Although its predicates belong to its complete concept, Leibniz distinguishes certainty from absolute necessity: "Caesar crosses the Rubicon" is certain in this chosen world but its opposite is conceivable in another possible world. God's selection under the Principle of Sufficient Reason makes the series hypothetically, not logically, necessary.

The difficulty is that an act fixed in the complete concept seems unable to be otherwise in the actual world. Leibniz's answer is compatibilist: reasons "incline without necessitating," and an action is free when it flows intelligently from the agent rather than from coercion. Thus freedom survives, but not as Cartesian indifference.

Verdict: Pre-established harmony leaves a defensible place for responsible self-expression, though not for libertarian alternative possibilities.

Why this earns marks: It answers "any place" directly, links harmony to spontaneity, names complete concepts and possible worlds, and qualifies the claim.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: What is the reason for the difference in the definitions and classifications of substances made by Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz in spite of the fact that they all belonged to the rationalist school of thought? Discuss.

Model solution

The difference arises not from abandoning rationalism but from successively tightening what counts as ontologically basic. All three inherit the idea that substance exists in itself and is conceived through itself; they disagree over independence, simplicity and individuation.

Descartes begins from clear-and-distinct **real distinction**. Thought and extension have mutually exclusive principal attributes, so mind and matter are created substances, while God is infinite substance. Yet *Principles* I.51 concedes that only God needs nothing whatever. "Substance" is therefore analogical: finite substances depend on God.

Spinoza applies the independence test strictly. In *Ethics* I, substances sharing an attribute cannot be distinct; a finite substance would have to be limited by another of the same nature. Hence only one infinite substance, God or Nature, exists. Minds and bodies become modes under Thought and Extension. This produces monism and pantheism but risks the acosmist charge that individuals lack independent reality.

Leibniz rejects both extended Cartesian substance and Spinozist absorption. Extension is divisible and composite, so it cannot be ultimate. True substances are simple centres of perception and appetite: infinitely many monads. The identity of indiscernibles differentiates them, while pre-established harmony explains correspondence without interaction. Bodies become well-founded phenomena.

Thus:

Revision	Criterion enforced	Result
Descartes	principal-attribute distinction	dualist created substances under God
Spinoza	absolute independence	one infinite substance

Revision	Criterion enforced	Result
Leibniz	simplicity and internal activity	infinitely many monads

Their shared rationalism supplies the deductive ambition, not a compulsory substance count. Indeed, the sequence is dialectical: Spinoza exposes Descartes' equivocation; Leibniz tries to restore individuality without returning to extended substance.

Verdict: "Substance" is a criterion whose interpretation generates the metaphysics. The trio's disagreement demonstrates rationalism's internal development rather than its incoherence.

Why this earns marks: It explains the *reason* for divergence, uses named doctrines, compares mechanisms and costs, and avoids a merely descriptive table.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: How does Descartes prove the existence of things other than himself and God? Discuss.

Model solution

After the cogito and the proof of a non-deceiving God, Descartes argues in *Meditation VI* that material things probably cause his involuntary sensory ideas. He possesses a passive faculty of receiving such ideas; this requires an active cause. He has a strong natural inclination to attribute them to bodies. If no bodies existed and God directly caused this inclination, God would deceive him. Since a perfect God is no deceiver, material things exist.

The proof establishes **res extensa** more securely than the complete accuracy of perception. Descartes allows that senses misreport size, colour or distance; reason must correct them. The wax argument had already shown that the essence of body is extension, flexibility and changeability grasped by intellect, not a catalogue of sensible qualities.

The argument's strength is systemic coherence: God bridges self and world. Its weakness is dependence on the contested divine proofs and Cartesian Circle. It also underdetermines whether external bodies resemble sensory appearances in detail.

Verdict: Descartes proves an external material cause within his system, but the result is only as secure as divine veracity.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs the causal argument, distinguishes existence from perceived qualities, and evaluates the theological dependence.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q2(c), 15 marks

Question: What do you understand by Spinoza's statement that what is, cannot be other than what it is? Explain.

Model solution

The statement expresses Spinoza's **necessitarianism**. God or Nature is the one self-caused substance, and *Ethics I* P16 holds that infinitely many things follow from the necessity of divine nature. Modes are not products of arbitrary choice; they follow from what substance is, as conclusions follow from adequate premises.

Three distinctions clarify the claim. First, God is free because God acts from the necessity of God's own nature, not because God could choose contrary possibilities (*Ethics I* Def. 7). Second, contingency is a name for human ignorance of causes; *Ethics I* P29 denies contingency in nature. Third, finite things are determined by other finite modes within the single causal order.

This does not entail passive fatalism. Under Thought, an adequate idea understands a cause; under Extension, the same order is expressed bodily (*Ethics II* P7). A person becomes relatively free by replacing inadequate passions with adequate activity and seeing things *sub specie aeternitatis*.

Critics argue that necessity erases responsibility and novelty. Spinoza replies that blame based on an uncaused will is confused; ethical improvement consists in increasing rational power. The reply preserves self-determination but abandons the ability to do otherwise.

Verdict: "Cannot be other" means metaphysical causal necessity, not external fate. Spinoza saves freedom only by redefining it as intelligent participation in necessity.

Why this earns marks: It derives the quotation from substance, distinguishes necessity from fatalism, and links metaphysics to ethics.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q1(b), 10 marks

Question: How does Leibniz's conception of monads bear upon his views on determinism and freedom? Discuss with your own comments.

Model solution

Monads are simple, windowless substances whose states arise internally through perception and appetite. Consequently, an agent is not mechanically pushed by other substances; conduct expresses the agent's complete concept. This supports determinism because the entire sequence is certain to God and coordinated through pre-established harmony.

Yet Leibniz treats internally sourced rational action as free. Freedom combines spontaneity, intelligence and contingency. The complete concept does not make acts logically necessary: other possible worlds contain alternative individuals and histories. Reasons incline the will without necessitating it in the way contradiction necessitates a truth.

In my view, the account successfully distinguishes coercion from self-expression and preserves responsibility better than Spinoza's strict necessitarianism. However, because the actual agent's complete concept is fixed, the availability of alternatives in other worlds may not satisfy a libertarian demand that this agent could now do otherwise.

Verdict: Monadology yields coherent compatibilism, not indeterministic freedom.

Why this earns marks: It connects monadic structure to both determination and freedom and includes the explicitly demanded personal assessment.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2020 Q4(b), 15 marks

Question: "From the necessity of the divine nature there must follow infinitely many things in infinitely many ways." Explain this statement by Spinoza along with some possible criticisms.

Model solution

In *Ethics* I P16, Spinoza derives the world from the essence of the one infinite substance. God has infinitely many attributes, each expressing eternal and infinite essence; therefore infinitely many modes follow in infinitely many ways. The relation is **immanent causation**: modes are in God, not external products made by a transcendent artisan.

The proposition supports four conclusions. God does not deliberate between worlds; divine action is necessary. Nothing is genuinely contingent; apparent contingency records ignorance. Thought and Extension express the same order under different attributes. Finite beings possess reality as modes, not independent substances.

Three criticisms follow. First, necessity threatens divine personality and worship: a God without choice resembles an impersonal order. Spinoza accepts the consequence and rejects anthropomorphism. Second, Hegel's acosmism objection says that if only substance is real, the finite disappears. Spinoza replies that modes are real as determinate expressions, though not self-subsistent. Third, strict derivation can seem to make evil and bondage divine necessities. Spinoza answers that good and evil are relational notions tied to human power, not properties of God.

Verdict: P16 gives Spinoza extraordinary systematic unity, but at the price of personality, contingency and robust individuality.

Why this earns marks: It explains the derivation, names P16 and immanent causation, and evaluates three distinct costs with replies.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2022 Q2(c), 15 marks

Question: Discuss the concept of substance according to Spinoza. Does his discussion on substance lead to pantheism? Substantiate your view.

Model solution

Spinoza defines substance as what is in itself and conceived through itself. In *Ethics* I, no two substances can share an attribute; substance cannot be finite because limitation would require another of the same nature. Therefore one absolutely infinite substance exists, possessing infinite attributes: God or Nature.

Thought and Extension are attributes known to human beings; particular minds and bodies are modes. *Ethics* I P15 states that whatever is, is in God, while P18 calls God the immanent rather than transitive cause. God does not stand outside and create Nature; *Natura naturans* and *Natura naturata* describe active nature and the order of modes.

This leads to pantheism in the precise sense that all reality is within and expressive of God, and nothing exists independently outside God. It is not crude identification of God with a mere aggregate of finite objects, because substance exceeds the two attributes humans know. The pantheist reading therefore qualifies but does not erase the pantheistic implication.

Hegel's acosmism charge argues that the finite becomes unreal. Yet modes possess dependent reality as expressions of substance. My view is that Spinoza is best described as a philosophically qualified pantheist: divine immanence is undeniable, while divine infinity prevents reduction to the visible world alone.

Why this earns marks: It takes and substantiates a position, uses P15/P18 and the attribute-mode distinction, and answers the pantheism/acosmism debate.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2022 Q4(b), 15 marks

Question: How does Rene Descartes explain the notion of certainty with reference to knowledge of the self? Critically discuss the way it differs from the knowledge of the world.

Model solution

Descartes discovers certainty by methodically suspending every belief vulnerable to sense error, dreaming or an evil demon. In *Meditation II*, "I am, I exist" is true whenever thought occurs: deception itself requires a deceived thinker. Knowledge of self is thus immediate, performative and independent of sensory mediation.

The self is first known as *res cogitans*: doubting, affirming, denying, imagining and seeming to sense. The wax case strengthens the priority claim: even if the wax does not exist, the act of judging reveals the judging mind. Hence mind is "better known" epistemically.

Knowledge of the world is mediate. Sensory ideas represent objects but can mislead; an external world is restored only after God's existence and non-deceptiveness are established. Even then, intellect identifies body's essence as extension, while reason corrects sensible appearances.

Critically, the cogito proves thinking existence, not automatically an enduring immaterial substance. Lichtenberg's later "there is thinking" objection and Hume's bundle critique expose this move. Moreover, the world-proof inherits the Cartesian Circle. Nevertheless, the asymmetry in certainty remains: self-presence survives the hypothesis under which world-presence is doubted.

Verdict: Descartes establishes epistemic priority of self over world, but not without further argument the full metaphysical dualism built upon it.

Why this earns marks: It compares modes of access, uses wax and divine veracity, and separates epistemic certainty from substantiality.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2023 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: "That thing is said to be free which exists solely from the necessity of its own nature, and is determined to action by itself alone." Discuss Spinoza's views on freedom and determinism in the light of the above statement.

Model solution

The quotation is *Ethics I* Definition 7. Spinoza rejects freedom as an uncaused choice. Every finite mode is determined within Nature's necessary order; humans imagine free will because they know desires but not their causes, as the conscious stone would mistake thrown motion for choice.

Only God is absolutely free because only God exists and acts from divine nature alone. Human freedom is relative: when inadequate ideas and external affects determine us, we are passive; when adequate ideas make us the adequate cause of action, we act from our understood nature. Reason and *scientia intuitiva* therefore transform necessity into self-determination.

The account is coherent but revisionary. It preserves rational agency and emotional liberation while denying alternative possibilities.

Verdict: Spinoza reconciles freedom with determinism by making freedom a higher form of determination, not an exception to causation.

Why this earns marks: It interprets the quoted definition, uses the stone analogy and adequate ideas, and ends with a qualified judgement.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2023 Q2(c), 15 marks

Question: Discuss Descartes' theory of innate ideas and the grounds on which Locke refutes it.

Model solution

Descartes distinguishes adventitious, factitious and innate ideas. Innate ideas are not necessarily explicit propositions present in an infant's consciousness; they are native capacities or intellectual contents, including God, substance, mind, extension and mathematical principles. In *Meditation* III, the idea of an infinite perfect being grounds the trademark argument because a finite mind cannot be its adequate total cause.

Locke attacks innate principles in *Essay* I. Universal assent is absent: children and persons without the relevant concepts do not consciously affirm alleged principles. Saying that principles are "in the mind" but unknown empties innateness of meaning, because by that standard every knowable truth would be innate. Locke instead begins with the mind as white paper and derives simple ideas from sensation and reflection.

Descartes can reply that innateness means a dispositional power, not constant awareness; geometrical knowledge is elicited rather than copied from sensation. Locke's argument decisively defeats crude occurrent innatism but less clearly defeats dispositional innatism. The empiricist must also explain necessity and universality without merely reporting repeated experience.

Verdict: Locke narrows the defensible Cartesian claim from preformed conscious truths to native cognitive structures; he refutes the caricature more securely than the strongest version.

Why this earns marks: It presents both theories fairly, identifies Locke's exact tests and gives a balanced adjudication.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks

Question: How does Spinoza establish that God alone is absolutely real with his statement - "Whatever is, is in God"? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Spinoza's conclusion follows from his substance argument. Substance is in itself and conceived through itself; no two substances can share an attribute; an absolutely infinite substance must possess every attribute. Therefore God alone is substance, and *Ethics* I P15 concludes that everything else exists in God as a mode.

"In God" is ontological, not spatial. A mind is a mode under Thought and a body a mode under Extension; neither can be conceived independently. P18 adds that God is the immanent cause of things. God is therefore absolutely real because divine existence and conception depend on nothing else, while finite reality is derivative.

The view avoids a creator-world dualism and explains parallelism elegantly. Yet it faces three objections: the individuality of modes appears weakened; modal change seems hard to reconcile with eternal substance; and a personal providential God disappears. Spinoza can reply that independent reality is not the only reality, temporal order belongs to finite modes, and personality would anthropomorphise infinity.

Verdict: God alone is absolutely real, but finite things are not nothing; they are real relational expressions. This makes Spinoza monist and pantheistic without committing him to simple world-denial.

Why this earns marks: It derives P15, explains "in," distinguishes absolute and modal reality, and critically handles individuality.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024 Q3(c), 15 marks

Question: Among the rationalists, whose account of mind-body problem is compatible with the notion of human freedom and free will? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Compatibility depends on the criterion of freedom. Descartes' interactionism separates unextended mind from mechanically determined body, permitting libertarian will. But Princess Elizabeth's objection remains: no intelligible account explains causal commerce between substances lacking a common property; the pineal gland merely gives a location.

Spinoza dissolves interaction by making mind and body the same mode under Thought and Extension (*Ethics* II P7). This is metaphysically economical but entails necessitarianism. Freedom becomes adequate self-determination, not

free will as alternative choice.

Leibniz denies interaction because windowless monads unfold internally. Pre-established harmony coordinates mental and bodily series. Rational action remains spontaneous, intelligent and contingent because the actual world is one possible world chosen by God; truths about action are certain but not absolutely necessary.

If “free will” means ability to do otherwise, Descartes wins but with an unintelligible causal theory. If it means responsible agency compatible with systematic determination, Leibniz offers the strongest account. Spinoza offers the deepest self-mastery but openly rejects free will.

Verdict: Leibniz is the best qualified answer because his mind-body theory preserves internal agency and moral responsibility without Cartesian interaction, though it remains compatibilist rather than libertarian.

Why this earns marks: It explicitly ranks all three against stated criteria and defends the winner rather than neutrally describing positions.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: What are the basic tenets of Rationalism? How does Descartes build a system of Philosophy in consonance with them? Discuss.

Model solution

Rationalism holds that reason can yield necessary and universal knowledge through innate or self-evident principles, deduction and an intelligible structure of reality. Experience may occasion thought, but it cannot alone provide the certainty modelled by mathematics.

Descartes embodies these tenets as a system:

1. **Method over authority:** the four rules of the *Discourse* and hyperbolic doubt reject inherited opinion and seek evident beginnings.
2. **Self-evident foundation:** the cogito is grasped by intellectual intuition, not inferred from sensory evidence.
3. **Innate content:** ideas of God, substance, mind, extension and mathematical truths are native to rational cognition.
4. **Deductive reconstruction:** from the thinking self Descartes argues to a perfect God through the trademark, conservation and ontological routes.
5. **Intelligibility and truth:** a non-deceiving God guarantees clear-and-distinct perception, restoring mathematics and the external world.
6. **Substance metaphysics:** reality is ordered into infinite God and the created principal attributes of thought and extension.
7. **Mechanistic nature and rational freedom:** extended nature is mathematically governed, while the will can withhold assent; error occurs when will outruns intellect.

The system is rationalist not merely because it praises reason but because each stage seeks necessity independent of sensory contingency. The wax argument even makes intellect, rather than the senses, the judge of bodily identity.

Its vulnerabilities are equally systematic. The cogito may prove only occurring thought, not a Cartesian substance. The trademark and ontological arguments are disputed. Arnauld’s Circle suggests that the divine guarantee presupposes the criterion it secures. Locke attacks innate principles, while Kant later denies that existence is a real predicate.

Verdict: Descartes constructs the paradigm rationalist system-foundational, innate, deductive and substance-based-but its success beyond the cogito depends on theological premises less indubitable than its method demands.

Why this earns marks: It first defines the school, then maps every tenet onto a stage in Descartes, and finally evaluates the load-bearing weaknesses.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2025 Q2(b), 15 marks

Question: “All determination is negation.” Comment with reference to Spinoza.

Model solution

The formula is associated with Spinoza's Letter 50—"determination is negation"—and universalised in Hegelian reception. To determine a finite thing is to bound it as this rather than that; every limit excludes alternatives. Finitude therefore contains negation.

In Spinoza's metaphysics, God or substance is absolutely infinite and determined by nothing external. God is pure positive self-expression through infinite attributes. Finite modes, by contrast, are limited by other modes: a body occupies this region and excludes others; a particular idea expresses only a bounded causal perspective. Their determination marks dependence and limitation.

The dictum also explains knowledge and freedom. Inadequate knowledge treats a finite thing in isolation; adequate knowledge understands it through the affirmative whole of Nature. The free person sees limitation and necessity *sub specie aeternitatis* rather than imagining an independent will.

Hegel's criticism is that Spinoza's infinite may swallow all finite determination, turning the world into negation-acosmism. Spinoza can answer that negation concerns independent self-subsistence, not every form of reality: modes positively express divine power in determinate ways.

Verdict: The dictum illuminates why finite beings are dependent, but it becomes reductive if limitation is mistaken for unreality. Spinoza needs both the negation of independence and the affirmation of modal expression.

Why this earns marks: It corrects provenance, explains the formula inside monism, links it to knowledge, and adjudicates the acosmism objection.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why the wax argument is necessary to Descartes' rationalist project even after the cogito.

Model solution

The cogito establishes only that thinking existence is indubitable whenever thought occurs. The wax argument in *Meditation II* extends the result by showing how bodily identity is cognised. A fresh piece of wax loses taste, smell, shape, hardness and sound near fire, yet is judged to be the same wax. Neither a fixed sensory catalogue nor imagination covering indefinitely many possible shapes explains this judgement; *inspectio mentis* does.

The case therefore supports two rationalist claims. First, intellect contributes the concept of an extended, flexible and changeable thing. Second, every judgement of wax more certainly reveals the judging mind, even if the object is absent. The hats-and-coats example similarly converts apparent seeing into intellectual judgement.

However, the argument may presuppose extension as body's essence, and an empiricist can treat it as abstraction. It proves intellectual structuring more clearly than innate knowledge.

Verdict: The wax turns the cogito from a bare certainty into an epistemological priority claim: mind is the condition under which body can be known.

Why this earns marks: It answers necessity, reconstructs the example, links it to rationalism and includes a precise limitation.

Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Is Spinoza's freedom merely determinism under a more attractive name? Critically examine.

Model solution

Spinoza is a strict necessitarian: *Ethics I* P29 denies contingency, and finite modes are causally determined. If freedom requires the ability to do otherwise under identical conditions, his theory is indeed determinism renamed.

Yet *Ethics I* Definition 7 distinguishes external determination from action flowing from one's own nature. Human bondage consists in inadequate ideas and passive affects produced by partial causal understanding. Through common notions, reason and *scientia intuitiva*, the person becomes an adequate cause of action. The conscious-stone analogy attacks ignorance, not agency as such.

This is more than rhetorical relabelling because the distinction between passive and active determination has ethical consequences: understanding an affect changes one's relation to it and increases rational power. Still, every achievement of understanding is itself necessary, and alternative possibilities never return.

Verdict: Spinoza offers a substantive compatibilist ideal of self-mastery, but not free will in the libertarian sense. Its success depends on whether freedom is defined by authorship or alternatives.

Why this earns marks: It states both criteria of freedom, names textual evidence, shows practical significance and gives a graded ruling.

Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "The history of rationalist substance is a movement from dualism through monism to pluralism." Analyse the logic and cost of this movement.

Model solution

The sequence 3 → 1 → ∞ captures a real dialectic, but its logic lies in changing criteria rather than numerical preference. Descartes, Spinoza and Leibniz all seek self-explanatory reality accessible to reason.

Descartes uses principal attributes and real distinction. God is infinite substance; mind and body are created substances whose essences are thought and extension. The gain is a clear basis for mathematical nature and personal consciousness. The cost is definitional equivocation and the interaction problem.

Spinoza applies independence consistently. If substance is conceived through itself, dependent created substances cannot qualify; substances sharing attributes cannot be distinct. God or Nature alone remains, while minds and bodies are modes under Thought and Extension. The gain is unity and dissolution of interaction. The cost is necessitarianism and the threat of acosmism.

Leibniz accepts that extended composites are not ultimate but refuses to sacrifice individuals. Simplicity, perception and appetite define infinitely many monads. The gain is active plurality and internal agency. The cost is that bodies become phenomenal and correspondence requires pre-established harmony and a divine selector.

Movement	Problem solved	New problem generated
Descartes → Spinoza	dependence and interaction between created substances	finite individuality and freedom weaken
Spinoza → Leibniz	restores genuine individual centres	harmony and complete concepts strain explanation

The movement is therefore neither linear progress nor arbitrary disagreement. Each successor enforces one rationalist demand more strictly while paying elsewhere: coherence, individuality and experiential plausibility cannot all be maximised simultaneously.

Verdict: Rationalist substance evolves through internal criticism, revealing that the definition of the basic unit already contains a theory of causation, individuality and freedom.

Why this earns marks: It analyses the movement, names mechanisms and textual doctrines, balances gains with costs, and concludes at the conceptual level.